Current Affairs 06-11-2026

Credit - Drishti Ias

Agnipath Scheme Reforms: 2-Year Extension and Pathway for Agniveer Retention

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For Prelims: Agnipath Scheme , Chief of Defence Staff , Central Armed Police Forces

For Mains: National security versus fiscal sustainability, Youth empowerment and nation-building, Defence reforms

Source: TH

Why in News?

The Union Cabinet has approved major changes to the **Agnipath Scheme ,** providing a **two-year service extension to the 75% of Agniveers** not initially selected for regular service, along with a pathway for their absorption into the regular cadre of the **Armed Forces.**

- The decision comes ahead of the exit of around 18,300 Agniveers completing their initial four-year tenure in December 2026.

Summary

- Agnipath Reforms introduce a two-year extension for the remaining 75% of Agniveers, with enhanced remuneration and a pathway to regular absorption, aiming to improve career security, retain trained personnel and address manpower shortages.
- Balancing personnel retention with defence modernisation, strengthening advanced warfare skills and ensuring effective rehabilitation of existing Agniveers remain critical for the scheme's success.

What are the Major Reforms to the Agnipath Scheme?

- **Introduction of a Two-Stage Absorption Process:**
  - **Stage 1 (Merit-Based Retention):** In alignment with the original scheme, **25% of Agniveers will**

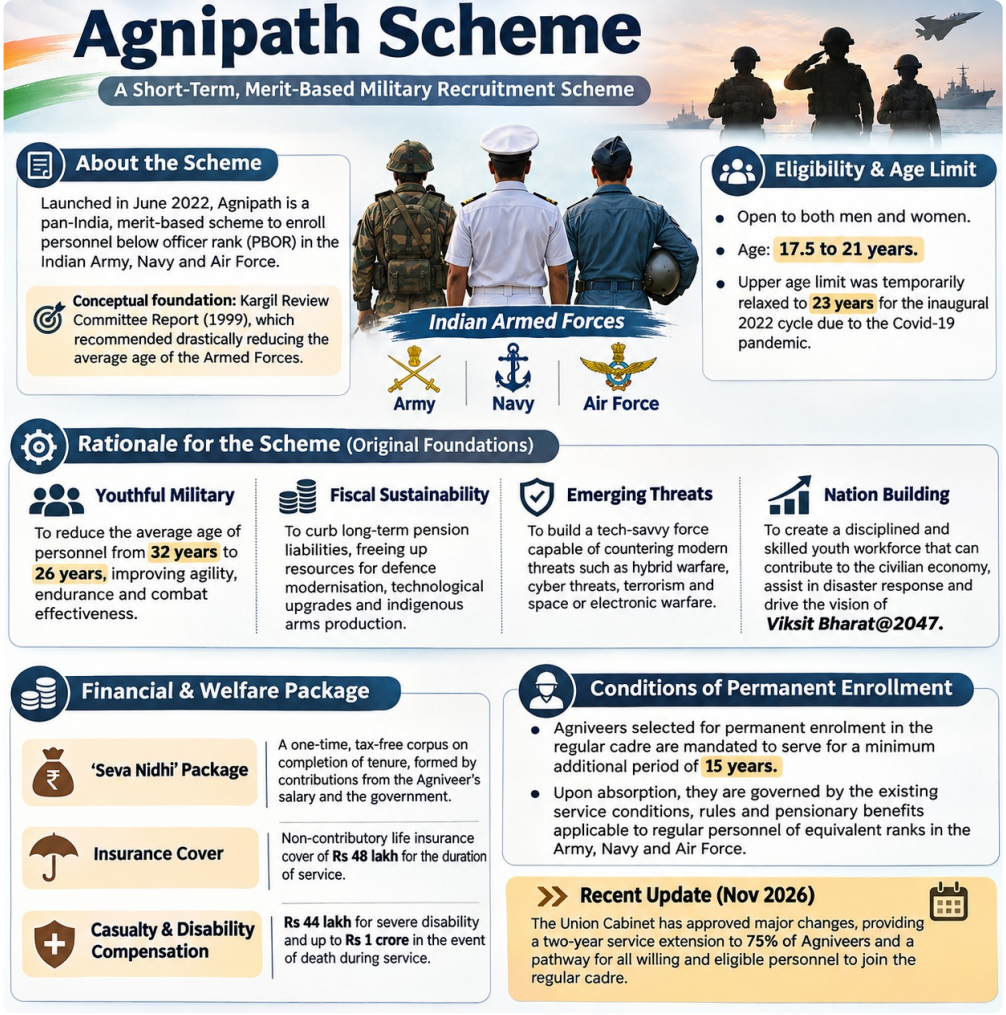
be absorbed into the regular services on merit at the end of their four-year tenure.

- **Stage 2 (The 'Second Tour of Duty'):** The remaining 75%, who were previously mandated to exit, will now be offered an additional **two-year extension** .
  - Following this, they will be eligible for enrolment as regular soldiers, subject to **willingness and strict military selection criteria.**

- **Enhanced Remuneration Structure:** Agniveers serving the extended two-year period will receive a significant pay hike. They will draw **Rs 43,500 in the first year** and **Rs 47,500 in the second year** (a sharp increase from the Rs 30,000 starting pay of the first batch).
- **Upgraded ‘Seva Nidhi’ Contributory Package:** For individuals who eventually opt to exit after the extended tenure, the **government's contribution to the Seva Nidhi corpus will increase to 70%** , **abandoning the previous 50-50 split between the soldier and the state.**
- **Relative Seniority of Regularised Agniveers:** Agniveers absorbed into the regular cadre after six years will be placed below their batchmates who entered regular service after four years, preserving the seniority distinction between the two routes.
- **Centralised Performance Tracking:** A centralized database has been established across all three services. Selection for regular enrolment will hinge on objective metrics like **greater adaptability, discipline, technological prowess, and a zero-vigilance record** .

Significance of the Reforms

- **Retention of Trained Personnel:** Retains experienced, **combat-trained Agniveers** for longer, maximising returns on military training investments.
- **Improved Career Security:** Addresses youth discontent over limited tenure and lack of long-term job security under the original scheme.
- **Addressing Pandemic-Era Recruitment Deficits:** A two-year recruitment freeze during the Covid-19 pandemic, combined with regular retirements, aggravated manpower shortages.
  - The Indian Army reportedly faced a **shortage of approximately 1.8 lakh personnel in November 2025,** highlighting the operational need to retain trained Agniveers.
- **Reduced Dependence on CAPF Reservations:** As noted by the **Chief of Defence Staff (CDS),** proposed internal career opportunities for Agniveers will reduce their reliance on post-service reservation benefits in **Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF)** .



What are the Challenges Regarding the Agnipath Scheme?

- **Inter-Service Differences in Manpower Requirements:** The three services have different operational requirements. Reportedly, the Navy had sought approximately 75% retention, while the Army and Air Force favoured 50%, highlighting the need for service-specific recruitment and retention planning.
- **Defence Fiscal Burden:** An objective of the original Agnipath Scheme was to reduce the ballooning **defence pension bill** .
  - By creating a pathway to **absorb a vast majority of Agniveers as regular,** pensionable soldiers, the scheme dilutes its **own fiscal consolidation goals** , re-introducing long-term financial liabilities for the state.
- **Pressure on Defence Capital Expenditure:** As revenue expenditure (salaries and pensions) rises again due to higher retention, it risks crowding out the vital **capital budget** .
  - This limits the financial bandwidth required for **military modernization** , indigenous defence procurement, and acquiring next-generation weapon systems.
- **Recruitment-Strength Balance:** Higher Agniveer retention may reduce fresh recruitment, requiring periodic recalibration of sanctioned strength and intake.
- **Erosion of *Esprit de Corps* :** The Indian Army's combat motivation relies heavily on the historic **regimentation system** (e.g., Rajputana Rifles, Sikh Regiment), built on lifelong bonds and shared identity.
  - The intense competition for permanent slots at the 4-year and 6-year marks threatens to **foster internal rivalries** , potentially undermining the mutual trust and camaraderie crucial for combat

units.

- **Strain on Training Infrastructure (Teeth-to-Tail Ratio):** A continuous cycle of **recruiting and evaluating short-term soldiers** places immense pressure on military training academies.
  - Diverting resources and manpower to manage constant training degrades the forces' **"teeth-to-tail" ratio, expanding the administrative backend at the cost of combat-ready frontline deployment.**
- **Socio-Economic Bottlenecks:** Despite higher retention rates, a fraction of Agniveers will still exit the service or fail the final six-year evaluation.
  - Transitioning these combat-trained youths into a highly competitive civilian job market remains a severe socio-economic challenge, as the **Seva Nidhi package** alone cannot replace long-term employment stability.
- **Reversal of the Youthful Demographic Goal:** The foundational premise of Agnipath stemming from the **Kargil Review Committee (1999),** was to drastically lower the average age of the **Indian Armed Forces** to 26 years.
  - By shifting toward near-complete permanent absorption of batches, the military risks gradually back to an older demographic profile over the next two decades.

What Measures are Needed for the Effective Implementation of Agnipath Scheme?

- **Re-calibrate the Defence Budget:** The Ministry of Defence must proactively ring-fence and secure non-lapsable capital funds to ensure that critical military modernization and **indigenous procurement (*Aatmanirbhar Bharat*) are not crowded out by revenue expenditure.**
- **Next-Gen Warfare Training:** To maximize the return on the extended "Second Tour of Duty," military training academies must heavily pivot toward modern, asymmetric warfare.
  - Agniveers in their 5th and 6th years must be upskilled in niche domains like **artificial intelligence, drone operations, cyber security, robotics, and electronic warfare to create a truly capability-based force.**
- **Robust Civilian Transition Ecosystems:** Moving beyond the *Seva Nidhi* financial buffer, India must build a comprehensive reintegration framework akin to the US G.I. Bill (a legislation funding full college education, housing, and career training for military veterans).
  - A "Whole of Government" approach is required to synergize the Agnipath exit cycle with the Defense Industrial Corridors (UP & Tamil Nadu).
  - Exiting Agniveers, already trained on advanced military platforms, must receive direct transition pathways into private defense manufacturing, defence R&D startups, and aviation maintenance, backed by formal degree bridge courses and rigorous skill certifications.
- **Establish Periodic Operational Reviews:** Conduct continuous, independent audits to assess the scheme's impact on **combat readiness** , **defence expenditure** , and **demographic shifts** , utilizing structural review frameworks akin to the **Shekatkar Committee (2015)** .
- **Transparent Career Progression:** Clearly define seniority, promotions, pension eligibility and career paths to prevent disparities and disputes.
- **Clarify Post-Service Employment Entitlements:** Issue clear guidelines on whether and how CAPF, PSU and State government reservation benefits will apply to Agniveers who voluntarily exit or are not absorbed after the extended tenure.

Conclusion

The 2026 reforms mark a shift towards a **flexible, capability-based recruitment model, addressing career uncertainties** and improving personnel retention. Their success, however, depends on **transparent merit-based selection and balancing human resource needs with defence modernisation** to strengthen India's national security.

Drishti Mains Question

Defence reforms must balance fiscal sustainability with operational preparedness. Critically analyse this statement in the context of the Agnipath Scheme.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/i_7_5V4JPj8**]

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Agnipath Scheme?
Launched in June 2022, it is a pan-India, merit-based military recruitment scheme for personnel below officer rank in the Army, Navy and Air Force.

2. What are the major changes introduced to the Agnipath Scheme in 2026?
The reforms provide a two-year service extension to the remaining 75% of Agniveers, with an opportunity for regular enrolment subject to willingness and selection criteria.

3. What is the Seva Nidhi package?
It is a one-time, tax-free financial package provided to Agniveers upon exit after their engagement period, comprising contributions from the Agniveer and the government.

4. What are the major objectives of the Agnipath Scheme?
To reduce the average age of the Armed Forces, improve operational readiness, reduce long-term pension liabilities and create a technologically skilled military workforce.

5. How do the reforms benefit the Armed Forces?
They help retain trained personnel, address manpower shortages, improve career security and strengthen operational preparedness.

Capex Support Scheme to Promote Critical Mineral Processing

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Union Cabinet approved the **CAPEX Support Scheme to Promote Critical Mineral Processing** to strengthen India's domestic processing capabilities, reduce import dependence and enhance critical mineral supply-chain security.

What are the Key Features of the CAPEX Support Scheme?

- **About:** The scheme, implemented by the **Ministry of Mines** , provides targeted capital expenditure (CAPEX) assistance to establish domestic **high-purity lithium and nickel processing facilities** , addressing a critical gap in India's mineral value chain.
- **Financial Outlay and Capital Subsidy:** The scheme has a total outlay of **₹2,814 crore** for five years (FY 2026–27 to FY 2030–31), **fully funded through Central Government** budgetary support, including ₹2,800 crore for capital subsidies and ₹14 crore for administrative expenses.
  - It provides a **30% subsidy on eligible investment** for establishing four processing plants:
    - **Lithium:** Two plants of at least 30 kilotonnes (kt) capacity each, with a maximum subsidy of ₹500 crore per beneficiary.
    - **Nickel:** Two plants of at least 50 kt capacity each, with a maximum subsidy of ₹900 crore per beneficiary.
- **Processing Focus:** Lithium plants will convert ores and concentrates (excluding brines) into battery-grade products, while nickel plants will produce Class-1 nickel or battery-grade nickel sulphate, with provision for cobalt recovery.
- **Beneficiary Selection:** Four beneficiaries (two each for lithium and nickel) will be selected through a **two-stage competitive process** , involving technical qualification followed by financial bidding based on the least-cost criterion (lowest CAPEX support sought).
- **Milestone-Based Disbursement:** Subsidies will be released in three tranches based on investment, equity contribution and commissioning milestones:
  - **25%:** Upon expenditure of 25% of committed CAPEX and contribution of at least 15% of the minimum required equity.
  - **50% (cumulative):** Upon expenditure of 50% of committed CAPEX and contribution of at least 50% of the minimum required equity.
  - **100% (cumulative):** Upon plant commissioning and contribution of 100% of the minimum required equity.
- **Commissioning Timeline:** Plants must be commissioned within **three years of the Letter of Award (LoA)** , with an outer limit of five years. Delays beyond three years will attract progressive reduction (tapering) of the remaining undisbursed subsidy.
- **Governance Framework:** A three-tier institutional mechanism will oversee implementation:
  - **Governing Council (GC):** Chaired by the Secretary, Ministry of Mines, it provides strategic guidance, selects beneficiaries, sanctions subsidies and monitors progress.
  - **Techno-Financial Committee (TFC):** Evaluates technical and financial proposals and recommends beneficiaries.

- **Project Management Agency (PMA):** Provides administrative and implementation support.



Why is Strengthening India's Critical Mineral Processing Capacity Important?

- **India's Critical Minerals:** A Ministry of Mines committee identified **30 critical minerals in 2023** , while **24 critical and strategic minerals** are listed under Part D of the First Schedule of the **MMDR Act, 1957** . India remains heavily dependent on imported refined mineral products and high-purity intermediates, highlighting gaps in domestic processing capabilities.
- **Applications:** Critical minerals are essential for **economic development, national security and the clean energy transition** , with applications in electric vehicles, electronics, telecommunications, aerospace and defence.
- **Strategic Security:** Global processing of critical minerals is concentrated in a few countries, exposing India to geopolitical disruptions, export restrictions and price volatility, thereby highlighting the need for diversified and resilient supply chains.
- **Rising Domestic Demand:** Expanding electric mobility, battery storage and advanced manufacturing, alongside India's **net-zero target of 2070** , is increasing demand for high-purity critical mineral products, necessitating domestic processing capacity.
- **High Investment and Technological Barriers:** Critical mineral processing requires advanced equipment, multi-stage conversion technologies and stringent environmental safeguards, resulting in high capital costs.
  - Limited access to raw materials, cost-effective technologies and technical expertise further constrains project viability, necessitating targeted government support.
  - Even with domestic processing facilities, dependence on imported ores and concentrates may persist, highlighting the need for diversified sourcing and overseas mineral partnerships.
- **Government Initiatives to Strengthen the Critical Mineral Value Chain:**
  - **National Critical Mineral Mission (NCMM) :** Launched in January 2025, it aims to secure long-term critical mineral supplies and strengthen the entire value chain, covering exploration, mining, processing and recycling.
    - A **₹1,500 crore recycling scheme** , approved in September 2025, promotes recovery of critical minerals from e-waste, spent lithium-ion batteries and other secondary sources, supporting a circular mineral economy.

- **Exploration and Mining:** The Central Government has auctioned **64 critical and strategic mineral blocks and 11 Exploration Licence blocks** , strengthening domestic resource development and supporting downstream processing.

What are the Expected Outcomes of the CAPEX Support Scheme?

- **Investment and Capacity Creation:** The scheme is expected to attract approximately **₹10,000 crore in investment** and establish **60 kilotonnes (kt) of lithium and 100 kt of nickel processing capacity** to meet projected demand by 2030.
- **Domestic Value Addition and Import Substitution:** Processing ores, concentrates and intermediates into high-purity products domestically will strengthen mineral value chains, reduce dependence on imported refined products and potentially lower foreign exchange outgo.
- **Supply Chain Resilience:** Domestic processing capacity will reduce exposure to geographically concentrated global refining hubs, export restrictions and supply disruptions.
- **Strengthening Downstream Industries:** Availability of domestically processed minerals will support battery materials, battery cells, electric vehicles, energy storage systems and speciality steel manufacturing.
- **Employment and Industrial Development:** Establishment of processing facilities and expansion of downstream manufacturing will generate direct and indirect employment and promote industrial growth.

Conclusion

The **CAPEX Support Scheme** strengthens **India's critical mineral value chain** by promoting domestic lithium and nickel processing, reducing import dependence and enhancing supply-chain resilience. Its success will depend on raw material security, technological capabilities and environmental sustainability, advancing **India's strategic autonomy and the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat .**

Drishti Mains Practice Question

India's dependence on imported processed critical minerals poses challenges to its energy transition and strategic autonomy. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is the CAPEX Support Scheme to Promote Critical Mineral Processing?
It is a Central Government scheme approved on 4 November 2026, with an outlay of ₹2,814 crore, to support the establishment of domestic lithium and nickel processing facilities.

Q2. What is the capital subsidy provided under the scheme?
The scheme provides a 30% capital subsidy on eligible investments, capped at ₹500 crore per lithium beneficiary and ₹900 crore per nickel beneficiary.

Q3. How many processing plants will be established under the scheme?
The scheme supports four processing plants, comprising two lithium plants with a minimum capacity of 30 kt each and two nickel plants with a minimum capacity of 50 kt each.

Q4. How will beneficiaries be selected?
Beneficiaries will be selected through a two-stage competitive process, involving technical qualification followed by financial bidding based on the lowest CAPEX support sought.

Q5. What is the National Critical Mineral Mission (NCMM)?
Approved in January 2025, NCMM aims to strengthen India's critical mineral security through exploration, mining, processing, overseas sourcing, recycling and technology development.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/lAachuI8NK0]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims :

Q1.Consider the following minerals: (2020)

1. Bentonite
2. Chromite
3. Kyanite
4. Sillimanite

In India, which of the above is/are officially designated as major minerals?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(B) 4 only

(C) 1 and 3 only

(D) 2, 3 and 4 only

Ans: D

Q2.Recently, there has been a concern over the short supply of a group of elements called 'rare earth metals'. Why? (2012)

1. China, which is the largest producer of these elements, has imposed some restrictions on their export.
2. Other than China, Australia, Canada and Chile, these elements are not found in any country.
3. Rare earth metals are essential for the manufacture of various kinds of electronic items and there is a growing demand for these elements.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(A) 1 only

(B) 2 and 3 only

(C) 1 and 3 only

(D) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: C

Mains :

Q . Discuss the multi-dimensional implications of uneven distribution of mineral oil in the world. **(2021)**

Fast Track Special Courts Scheme Extended Till

2031

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Source: TH

Why in News?

The Union Cabinet has approved the continuation of the **Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS) for Fast Track Special Courts (FTSCs),** including exclusive **POCSO Courts,** for a further period of five years (FY 2026–27 to FY 2030–31).

What is the Fast Track Special Courts (FTSCs) Scheme?

- **About:** FTSCs launched in October 2019 following the **Criminal Law (Amendment) Act, 2018** and the Supreme Court's directions in **Suo Motu Writ (Criminal) 2019,** which directed the establishment of exclusive Special Courts in districts having more than 100 pending POCSO cases.
  - The scheme facilitates **speedy disposal of pending rape and Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012 cases through dedicated courts.** This includes the establishment of **Exclusive POCSO (e-POCSO) Courts** , which solely handle child sexual abuse cases.
  - After two extensions covering 790 courts until March 2026, it has now received a **third extension for five years (FY 2026–27 to FY 2030–31).**
- **Constitutional Backing:** The Supreme Court recognizes the right to a speedy trial as an integral part of **Article 21 (Right to Life and Personal Liberty)** , as established in the landmark ***Hussainara Khatoon v. Home Secretary, State of Bihar (1979)*** .
- **Constitutional Scrutiny:** The Supreme Court **(*State of West Bengal v. Anwar Ali Sarkar, 1952*)** ruled that classifying cases for **fast-track trials must have a rational, objective basis** (e.g., offense gravity or victim vulnerability); arbitrary classification based on "speed" alone violates equality before the law.
- **Evolution of Scope:** The **14 th Finance Commission (2015–2020)** significantly expanded the scope of Fast Track Courts (FTCs) by recommending them for heinous crimes (such as murder, kidnapping, and extortion), civil property disputes pending for over five years, and cases involving vulnerable groups.
- **Efficiency:** FTSCs dispose of an average of about 9.5 cases per month compared to 3.3 cases per month in regular subordinate courts.

Key Features of the Extended FTSCs Scheme

- **Financial Outlay and Funding:** The extended scheme has a total financial outlay of **Rs 3,788 crore** .
  - The Central Government will contribute Rs 2,353 crore, while participating States and Union Territories will contribute Rs 1,434 crore. The Central Government's share is funded entirely through the **Nirbhaya Fund** .
- **Capacity Building:** The expanded program targets the operation of up to **850 fast-track courts** across the country.
  - Currently, 29 States/UTs are participating, operating 779 functional FTSCs (including 399 exclusive

POCSO courts).

- **Dedicated Personnel:** Special Public Prosecutor exclusively assigned to each FTSC and six support staff members to ensure judicial efficiency.
- **Child-Friendly Infrastructure:** The scheme encourages the establishment of **Vulnerable Witness Deposition Centres (VWDCs)** and child-friendly courts to reduce psychological stress and protect the privacy of survivors during testimonies.
- **Monitoring & Evaluation:** The **Department of Justice monitors FTSC performance through the FTSC Dashboard** , progress reports and expenditure statements, in consultation with High Courts and State Governments.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. When was the Fast Track Special Courts Scheme launched and under which Act?
Launched in October 2019, following the Criminal Law (Amendment) Act, 2018 and Supreme Court directions in Suo Motu Writ (Criminal) No. 1/2019.

2. What is the duration and financial outlay of the extended FTSC Scheme?
The scheme has been extended for five years (FY 2026–27 to FY 2030–31) with a total outlay of ₹3,788 crore.

3. What is the funding pattern of the extended FTSC Scheme?
The Centre contributes ₹2,353 crore, while States and UTs contribute ₹1,434 crore. The Central share is funded through the Nirbhaya Fund.

4. What is the target capacity of the extended FTSC Scheme?
The scheme targets up to 850 courts. Currently, 779 FTSCs, including 399 exclusive POCSO Courts, are functional across 29 participating States/UTs.

5. What is the constitutional basis for speedy trials in India?
The right to a speedy trial is an integral part of Article 21, recognised by the Supreme Court in Hussainara Khatoon v. State of Bihar (1979).

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/_l4Y8TfzmbE**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With reference to Lok Adalats, which of the following statements is correct? (2010)

(a) Lok Adalats have the jurisdiction to settle the matters at pre-litigation stage and not those matters pending before any court

(b) Lok Adalats can deal with matters which are civil and not criminal in nature

(c) Every Lok Adalat consists of either serving or retired judicial officers only and not any other person.

(d) None of the statements given above is correct

Ans: D

Mains

Q. We are witnessing increasing instances of sexual violence against women in the country. Despite existing legal provisions against it, the number of such incidences is on the rise. Suggest Some innovative measures to tackle this menace. **(2014)**

VGF Scheme for Grid-Scale Energy Storage Systems

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Source: PIB

The Union Cabinet has approved the **Viability Gap Funding (VGF) Scheme for Development of Grid-Scale Energy Storage Systems,** with a total financial support of Rs.14,500 crore for the period **FY 2026-27 to FY 2030-31** , driving India's renewable energy integration, grid stability, and long-term energy security.

- **Targeted Capacity:** The scheme aims to develop **92 Gigawatt-hours (GWh)** of new Grid-Scale Energy Storage capacity, equivalent to 170% of existing Grid Scale **Energy Storage System** capacity, contributing towards **India's target of 411 GWh by 2031–32.**
- **Sub-Sector Allocation:** The 92 GWh target is divided into **60 GWh of Hydro Pumped Storage Projects (PSPs)** , **30 GWh of Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS)** , and **2 GWh from alternative/emerging energy storage technologies** .
- **Bidding Process:** Projects will be allocated to both **public and private sector electricity distribution companies (DISCOMs)** through a **tariff-based competitive bidding process** .
- **Push for 'Make in India':** To reduce import dependence and promote indigenous production, a mandatory **minimum Domestic Content Requirement (DCR) of 40% has been set for BESS projects** .
  - The scheme provides demand-side financial support, complementing existing supply-side incentives for battery manufacturing and strengthening India's domestic energy storage ecosystem.
- **Strategic Significance:** The scheme is crucial for **balancing electricity supply and demand** , addressing the **variability of renewable energy generation** , and ensuring **reliable, round-the-clock (RTC) power supply** without over-relying on conventional fossil fuels.
- **Economic & Infrastructure Impact:** The scheme is expected to attract an **estimated total investment of Rs 97,600 crore** , supporting India's transition towards a cleaner and more resilient electricity system.
- **Viability Gap Funding (VGF):** It is a one-time government capital grant provided to infrastructure projects that are economically essential but financially unviable.
  - It bridges the gap between **high initial investment and low commercial returns, attracting private investment** while ensuring affordable services.

Read more: India's Renewable Energy Transition

VISTAR Scheme for Modernisation of India's Statistical System

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Source: PIB

The Union Cabinet approved the **Viksit Bharat Initiative for Statistical Transformation, Analytics & Research (VISTAR), a Central Sector Scheme** with an outlay of **₹4,371.10 crore for 2026–27 to 2030–31,** to modernise India's official statistical system in alignment with **Viksit Bharat 2047 .**

- **Nodal Ministry:** The **Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)** will implement the scheme to establish a real-time, interoperable, AI-ready and future-oriented statistical architecture.
- **Objective:** Strengthen data quality, timeliness, granularity, digital integration and evidence-based policymaking with flexible resource allocation based on evolving policy requirements.
- **Three Major Components:**
  - **Comprehensive Statistical Operations and Strengthening of Ecosystem:** Proposes **59 surveys during the 16th Finance Commission cycle** , compared with 43 major surveys previously, alongside end-to-end digitalisation of statistical processes.
  - **Support for Statistical Strengthening (SSS 2.0):** Provides deliverable-linked financial and technical assistance to States/UTs to improve statistical capacity, develop indigenous data-processing capabilities and generate district-level and other disaggregated data.
    - It also supports **district-level and million-plus-city estimates under PLFS , HCES and ASUSE , alongside State/District GDP and State-level IIP** compilation.
  - **Economic Census:** Undertakes the **8th Economic Census** in collaboration with States/UTs to collect detailed information on non-farm establishments and workers down to Gram Panchayat and Ward levels.
    - It will provide the baseline for the **National Statistical Business Register (SBR),** support targeted enterprise surveys and help estimate the **unorganised sector's** contribution to GDP.
- **AI and Digital Transformation:** Integrates **Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Machine Learning (ML)** into statistical data processing, validation and analysis.
- **New Statistical Indicators:** Proposes introducing the **Headline Index of Services Production and Index of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises** to improve measurement of economic activity.
- **Alternative Data Sources:** Promotes the **use of mobile phone, scanner and e-commerce data to complement conventional surveys** , reduce respondent burden and address information gaps.
- **Data Governance:** Focuses on **data cataloguing, harmonisation, machine readability, interoperability, secure data-sharing protocols** and privacy by design to reduce fragmentation and improve data integration.
- **Statistical Capacity Building:** Supports student internships, academic research proposals and technical training to strengthen statistical research and human resources.

Read More: India’s Statistical Database Overhaul

Indian Navy Launches NGOPV Srishti

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Source: PIB

Srishti , a **Next Generation Offshore Patrol Vessel (NGOPV)** for the Indian Navy, was launched at **Goa Shipyard Limited (GSL), Goa** .



- **About: Srishti, a** NGOPVs will support **maritime surveillance, Search and Rescue (SAR), protection of offshore assets, Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR), and anti-piracy missions** .
  - The launch strengthens India's **indigenous naval shipbuilding capability** under **Aatmanirbhar Bharat and Make in India** .
- **Next Generation Offshore Patrol Vessels:** These ships are capable of fulfilling roles such as Seaward Defence, 'Out of Area' Contingency Ops (OOAC), Non-Combatant Evacuation Ops (NEO), Convoy Operations/Anti-Piracy Missions, Counter Infiltration Ops etc.

Read More: **Surya: Indian Navy's 1st Indigenously Built Fleet Support Ship**